

THE STUDY • SUBMITTED • UNDER REVIEW • SPIRITUALITY IN MENTAL HEALTH

Do people who meditate for years differ from those who don't? A comparison of long-term SOS meditators and non-meditators



Department of Counseling, University of North Carolina at Charlotte



Department of Counselor Education, University of Central Florida

75

LONG-TERM SOS MEDITATORS

vs.

67

NON-MEDITATORS

Long-term SOS meditators reported lower *stress*, lower *depression*, and a greater sense of *meaning in life*.



WHO
142 adults, two groups compared

75 long-term Science of Spirituality (SOS) meditators were surveyed alongside 67 non-meditators. Self-selected, cross-sectional sample.



WHAT WAS MEASURED
4 well-validated questionnaires

Perceived stress, depression symptoms, ruminative thinking, and meaning in life (includes presence of meaning and search for meaning).



WE FOUND
Lower stress & depression

Experienced meditators scored significantly lower on stress and depression than non-meditators. They also reported a greater sense of meaning in life.

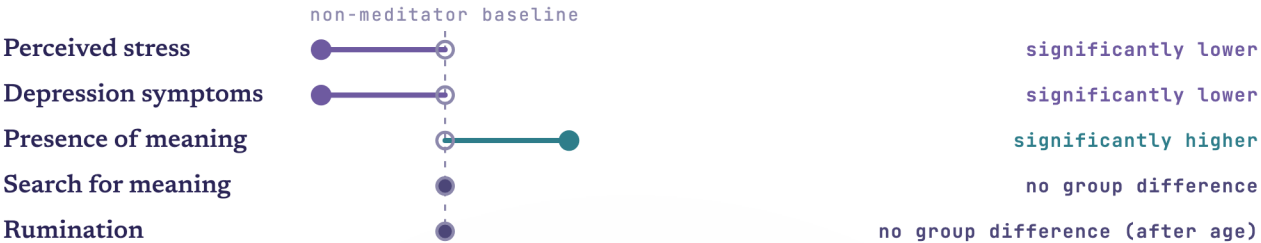


WHERE IT EVENED OUT
Not everything differed

After controlling for age, the two groups did not differ on rumination or on the active search for meaning in life.

DIRECTION OF EFFECTS

Long-term meditators vs. non-meditators, by outcome



Schematic — direction of effect only. Solid dots show the meditator group's position relative to the dashed non-mediator reference. Solid lines show statistically significant gaps after age adjustment.

WHAT WE CAN — AND CAN'T — SAY A cross-sectional comparison, not a clinical trial.

✓ WE CAN SAY: People with years of SOS practice **tend to report** lower stress, lower depression, and a stronger sense of meaning than non-meditators.

ⓘ WE CAN'T SAY: That meditation **caused** these differences. Meditators chose to practice; pre-existing differences could explain part of the pattern. A randomized trial is needed for causal claims.

→ **Manuscript currently under peer review.** Findings are preliminary until published; details and effect sizes will be available in the final paper.

HOW TO READ THIS

Cross-sectional design — participants self-selected into the meditator group. Findings are associations, not causal claims. Under peer review; details may change in the final published version.

CITATION (UNDER REVIEW)

Young ME, Gutierrez D, Niles JK, Dorais S, Ritz LA. Characteristics of experienced meditators vs. non-meditators: clinical implications. *Submitted to Spirituality in Mental Health, 2026*. Authors' institutions: University of Central Florida; Virginia Commonwealth University; University of North Carolina at Greensboro; College of William & Mary; University of Florida.

